Muslim territories. Within the year, he had whipped most of the Muslim cities into line.[10]

In 1172, he made his first foray against the Christian position. He laid siege to the city of Huete—and failed.

There were multiple reasons for the failure. At least one eyewitness suggests that Yusuf I, perhaps underestimating his enemy, wasn't particularly engaged in the siege; instead of appearing on the battlefield, he remained in his tent, carrying on philosophical discussions with his advisors. The twenty thousand Almohad troops were an uneasy mixture of local Spaniards, Arabs, and North Africans; they all had their own native commanders and did not act easily in unison. They were forced to forage farther and farther afield for food. A message came from the pope to Huete, promising the city's defenders remission from sin for their efforts and stiffening their resolve. And just as the inhabitants began to suffer from thirst, a massive rainstorm refilled the city's reservoirs.[11]

When the news went around the Almohad camp that Alfonso VIII of Castile (now eighteen and ruling in his own name) was approaching to lift the siege, the Almohads gave up their position and retreated. It was an embarrassing defeat for Yusuf I, although not fatal; he would soon regather himself and relaunch the war.

But Huete was a turning point for the Christian kingdoms, which now began to readjust their attitudes towards each other. By 1177, all five of the Christian kings had sworn out treaties or created marriage alliances. The political unity of Alfonso the Battler had become a unity of purpose; and the latticework of allegiances woven by the Christian enemy would prove almost impossible for the Almohads to penetrate.